

A REUSABLE FIELD COMPANION

The Warrior Teacher's Playbook

A Field Journal for Turning Strategy into Practice

Print the pages you need. Complete them digitally. Return to them whenever the field changes.

MATTHEW PHAM

COMPANION TO THE ART OF WAR FOR EDUCATORS

How to Use This Companion

A field journal becomes useful only when it helps you see, choose, and learn more honestly.

This companion does not turn teaching or leadership into a formula. It gives the questions in the Playbook enough space to be used more than once, in more than one room, and with more than one kind of learner.

USE IT IN THREE WAYS

Before the moment

Prepare for a lesson, meeting, conversation, transition, or decision that matters.

After the moment

Study what happened without letting the first emotional story become the final explanation.

With another perspective

Invite a learner, colleague, family member, support professional, work sample, or responsible AI use to test what you think you saw.

WHAT THE MARKS MEAN

A checkbox belongs beside something you can honestly observe, confirm, or complete. A response field asks you to gather evidence, slow down, and decide what the moment requires. There is no correct way to complete this companion. Write, speak, discuss, or use one page and leave the rest untouched. Blank space does not mean unfinished work.

Professional boundary

This is practitioner reflection, not a diagnostic instrument or validated intervention. It does not replace safeguarding procedures, emergency action, institutional policy, qualified professional judgment, or consent and privacy requirements.

Choose the Depth the Moment Requires

Do not begin with the biggest tool. Begin with the smallest page capable of improving the next decision.

QUICK MOVE

Five minutes or less: Strategic Pause, 5-Minute Lesson Audit, or Monday Move.

DEEPER REFLECTION

Understand a learner, relationship, or recurring pattern: Reading the Room, Strength Finder, Self-Check, or Pattern Practice.

ETHICAL DECISION

Working with a powerful method, sensitive information, or AI: Ethical Ignition, Foreknowledge, Responsible AI, or Teaching AI Through Reflection.

LONGER INQUIRY

Study change across several days or weeks: Weekly Field Journal, Terrain Inquiry Cycle, and Practice Evidence Log.

A SIMPLE STARTING SEQUENCE

- ☐ Pause once before reacting.
- ☐ Read one real moment without assigning motive.
- ☐ Choose one small move.
- ☐ Watch for evidence that supports or challenges your reading.
- ☐ Return and revise.

The deeper tools are not more important.

They simply give a complex moment more room. A small page used honestly is stronger than an impressive framework used carelessly.

Translate the Language Without Losing the Purpose

The Playbook belongs in classrooms, but its responsibility travels farther.

Teacher or educator

Coach, mentor, parent, counsellor, administrator, team leader, or designer

Learner or student

The person, group, or, where applicable, intelligent system whose growth you are supporting

Classroom

Studio, field, court, office, meeting, workshop, home, team, or digital environment

Lesson

Shared task, project, conversation, practice, decision, or next stage of growth

Learning evidence

What changed in understanding, action, confidence, ownership, relationship, or responsible performance

Keep the ethical centre

Whatever language you use, the person is never the enemy. The tool exists to protect purpose, dignity, agency, trust, and the possibility of growth.

An Optional Four-Week Practice Path

Use this only if a sequence helps. The Playbook should support the work, not become another burden.

WEEK 1 • NOTICE

Use the Strategic Pause once and Reading the Room once. Practise separating observation from assumption.

WEEK 2 • PROTECT

Use the Strength Finder and Teacher Self-Check. Practise holding both dignity and direction.

WEEK 3 • WIDEN

Use Responsible AI or another trusted perspective, then complete one Pattern Practice. Practise allowing new evidence to change your mind.

WEEK 4 • STUDY

Use the Weekly Field Journal and Terrain Inquiry Cycle. Practise watching what changes across time.

My reason for beginning

What would make this practice worth the time?

Evidence I hope to notice

What change would matter without pretending one tool can prove causation?

Completed Example 1: Reading a Difficult Moment

This neutral example demonstrates the discipline of separating evidence from interpretation.

Situation

A group is talking during independent work.

Observed

Several learners are talking, two have stopped working, and the instructions remain visible.

First story

They are choosing not to care.

Alternative possibilities

The first step may be unclear, the task may feel too difficult, or the group may need a clearer time boundary.

Small move

Pause the room, restate the purpose, model the first step, and provide five focused minutes before checking again.

Signal

Are learners beginning, asking more useful questions, or showing the same confusion?

Review

Keep the adjustment if it improves clarity and participation. Change it if the evidence shows that the barrier is somewhere else.

Completed Example 2: Responsible AI Use

This is an illustrative scenario, not a claim about one lived classroom.

Purpose

A teacher wants three alternative ways to explain equivalent fractions before meeting a group that struggled with the first explanation.

Privacy

The prompt includes the learning goal and anonymized task. It contains no learner names, records, diagnoses, or identifying details.

What AI widened

It suggests a paper-folding model, a number-line comparison, and a shopping analogy.

What the teacher rejected

The shopping example assumes experiences that may not be shared and adds unnecessary language.

What the teacher checked and kept

The paper-folding and number-line models are mathematically verified, adapted to available materials, and selected because they preserve the learning intention.

Responsibility

The teacher decides what enters the room, watches how learners respond, and changes course if the new route does not help.

Why this is responsible

The system widens possibilities. The educator protects context, accuracy, privacy, ownership, and the final decision.

Completed Example 3: A Terrain Inquiry

This example shows how to study one adjustment without claiming that a single observation proves a universal result.

Question

Could a clearer material-return system reduce waiting and protect creation time during transitions?

Evidence before

Across three lessons, cleanup begins late, several learners wait without a role, and materials return to inconsistent places.

Adjustment

Introduce labelled return areas, two visible time warnings, and rotating student responsibilities.

Evidence after

During the next three lessons, more learners begin cleanup at the first cue and fewer ask where materials belong.

Another perspective

A teaching assistant notices that the final tables are restored more consistently but one role still creates a bottleneck.

Revision

Divide the overloaded role and observe again.

Honest conclusion

The adjustment appears useful in this setting. It deserves continued observation; it does not prove that the same design will work everywhere.

Field Tool 1: The Strategic Pause • Before

Use before a lesson, meeting, conversation, correction, or difficult decision.

Mission

What matters beyond completing the immediate task?

Learner or people in front of me

Who may be affected by this decision?

What I have actually observed

Record evidence without assigning motive or identity.

What I may be assuming

What story have I added?

What must be protected

Safety, dignity, trust, learning, time, relationship, or something else?

Smallest wise move

What can improve the situation without closing future possibilities?

Field Tool 1: The Strategic Pause • After

Return after the moment. The purpose is not to prove yourself right.

What actually happened

What changed, and what remained?

What the room revealed

What did the response tell me about clarity, energy, relationship, access, or purpose?

Where I read wisely

Which evidence supported my first reading?

Where I reacted

Where did emotion, ego, fatigue, or urgency narrow my view?

Perspective that challenges my account

What did another person, work sample, or later observation reveal?

What I will carry forward

Keep, adapt, release, or investigate?

Field Tool 2: The 5-Minute Lesson Audit

Check only what you can honestly confirm. An unchecked item shows where preparation may need attention.

- ☐ Purpose: The learning matters beyond completing the task.
- ☐ Clarity: Learners can see where to begin and what success may look like.
- ☐ Energy: I have considered whether this moment needs calm, momentum, curiosity, challenge, movement, or stillness.
- ☐ Access: I have prepared a bridge for anyone who may struggle to enter the learning.
- ☐ Extension: I have a meaningful next step for anyone who may be ready for more.

One adjustment before I begin

Fix one thing rather than redesigning everything.

Evidence I will watch for

What will tell me the adjustment is helping?

What I will do if the evidence disagrees

Prepare to change the route without abandoning the purpose.

One clear adjustment can protect an entire class.

Preparation is not control. It is care made visible before the moment asks for it.

Chapter 1 Field Notes: Laying Plans

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

What am I trying to build beyond the activity itself?

Where might my plan be clear to me but unclear to the learner?

What assumptions am I carrying into the room?

What would preparation look like if I planned for the learner, not only the lesson?

One move I will try

Before teaching, write one sentence that names the real purpose of the lesson. Not the task. The purpose.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Help me identify the deeper learning purpose behind this lesson and suggest three ways to make that purpose visible to learners.

Chapter 2 Field Notes: Waging War

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

Where am I spending energy without gaining learning?

What is exhausting me because the system is unclear?

What routine, boundary, or expectation needs to be strengthened?

Where am I relying on effort when a better structure would help everyone?

One move I will try

Choose one recurring problem and design one small routine that prevents it before it grows.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Here is a recurring challenge. Help me design a simple routine that protects learning while maintaining dignity.

Chapter 3 Field Notes: Attack by Stratagem

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

Where am I trying to force a result that could be reached more wisely?

What barrier is really standing between the learner and the learning?

How can I win the learner without fighting the learner?

Where can I protect the relationship while still protecting the standard?

One move I will try

Find one moment where you usually correct quickly. Pause first and ask what the behaviour might be protecting, avoiding, or communicating.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Generate possible reasons a learner might resist this task, and suggest supportive responses without lowering the expectation.

Chapter 4 Field Notes: Tactical Dispositions

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

What conditions need to be in place before learners can succeed?

Where am I expecting confidence before I have created safety?

What would make the learning environment feel more prepared?

What can I arrange now so learners do not have to fight unnecessary confusion later?

One move I will try

Set up one part of the environment, routine, or material flow so success becomes easier before the task begins.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Help me audit this learning experience for possible points of confusion, anxiety, or avoidable friction.

Chapter 5 Field Notes: Energy

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

Where is the energy in the room coming from?

Where is it leaking?

What kind of energy does this group need from me today: calm, momentum, humour, clarity, challenge, or care?

Am I using my energy to guide the room or to chase the room?

One move I will try

Notice one moment when energy shifts. Name what changed before choosing your response.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Suggest three ways to increase engagement in this experience without turning it into entertainment.

Chapter 6 Field Notes: Weaknesses and Strengths

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

Who might I be underestimating?

What strength may be hidden behind a learner's struggle?

Where have I accepted a label too quickly?

What might become possible if I looked again?

One move I will try

Choose one learner you have mostly seen through difficulty. Look again for one strength and create one opportunity for them to use it.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Help me reframe this challenge through a strengths-based lens and suggest one opportunity that could reveal hidden ability.

Chapter 7 Field Notes: Maneuvering

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

Where is the path no longer clear?

What is the room asking me to adjust?

Am I holding the mission, or am I holding the plan?

What route could still lead to the same destination?

One move I will try

Prepare one alternate route before the lesson begins: another example, entry point, pace, or way back.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Give me three alternative routes into this learning: one visual, one hands-on, and one discussion-based.

Chapter 8 Field Notes: Variation in Tactics

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

What usual method might not be the right method for this moment?

Where does choice support learning, and where does it create drift?

What is the best tactic the moment requires?

Where might the method need to bend so the learner does not break?

One move I will try

Identify one part of the experience where you can vary the approach without changing the purpose.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Suggest variations for this experience while keeping the learning intention the same.

Chapter 9 Field Notes: The Army on the March

Use the questions that matter. Leave the others until the field gives you a reason to return.

What is the room whispering before it shouts?

What signals am I noticing in noise, silence, movement, materials, body language, or timing?

Who else helps me read the environment more clearly?

What small signal have I been ignoring because the larger problem has not arrived yet?

One move I will try

Watch one transition carefully. Do not only ask whether it worked. Ask what it revealed.

OPTIONAL AI COMPANION

Help me create a simple observation checklist for transitions, routines, and early warning signs of confusion or disengagement.

Chapter 10 Field Notes: Terrain

These terrains describe conditions around learning. They do not define the learner.

ACCESSIBLE

Signal: The first step, purpose, language, and materials are within reach.

Strategic move: Protect clarity and momentum.

ENTANGLING

Signal: An early misunderstanding can make every later step harder to recover.

Strategic move: Build checkpoints before confusion grows roots.

TEMPORIZING

Signal: Pushing harder would create more pressure without creating more progress.

Strategic move: Pause and gather better information.

NARROW PASSES

Signal: Time, safety, materials, or competing demands leave little room for error.

Strategic move: Secure the essentials early.

PRECIPITOUS HEIGHTS

Signal: The challenge is advanced, high-pressure, or difficult to reverse.

Strategic move: Build skill, confidence, and safety first.

DISTANT

Signal: The destination feels too far from where the learner currently stands.

Strategic move: Break the distance into visible milestones.

Chapter 10: The Terrain Check

Read the conditions without turning the terrain into a label.

Terrain I may be encountering

Which description helps me think without claiming certainty?

Evidence rather than assumptions

What have I actually seen, heard, read, or measured?

What is helping learning

What is quietly working against it

What must be protected

Wisest next move

Signal that the terrain has changed

Chapter 11 Field Notes: The Nine Situations

Use these as prompts, never as labels.

DISPERSIVE

Purpose is scattered. Create a shared centre.

FACILE

The learner has begun, but commitment has not formed. Make the first step meaningful.

CONTENTIOUS

People are pulling toward competing advantages. Protect the purpose, not the contest.

OPEN

Choice is abundant. Give freedom a clear horizon.

INTERSECTING HIGHWAYS

Many people and pathways meet. Connect observations before drawing conclusions.

SERIOUS

The work carries real stakes. Protect the time, trust, materials, and support needed to continue.

DIFFICULT

Each step costs more. Make the next foothold visible without lowering the destination.

HEMMED-IN

The learner cannot see a respectful way back. Hold the boundary while keeping redemption possible.

DESPERATE

Safety or safeguarding has become the priority. Follow accountable procedures and involve the right support.

Chapter 11: The Situational Scan • Read

Use this page to think before reacting.

What I have actually observed

Separate evidence from motive.

Story or assumption I may have added

Alternative explanation I have not yet ruled out

Situation or situations that may help me think

More than one may be relevant.

Evidence that could prove my first reading incomplete

Chapter 11: The Situational Scan • Respond

The next move should protect the person and preserve the possibility of learning.

What must be protected first

Safety, dignity, trust, learning, time, or something else?

Who else may hold part of the picture**Smallest humane move****Signal that will tell me to change the strategy****What happened after the move****What the first reading missed**

Chapter 12: The Ethical Ignition Check • Design

Use before introducing a method powerful enough to change energy, pace, access, or direction.

Human capacity I am trying to ignite

Why this method is more useful than a quieter one

Situation and terrain surrounding the learners

Who has access, and who may be left outside the design

Boundaries protecting safety, dignity, privacy, integrity, and choice

Chapter 12: The Ethical Ignition Check • Evidence

The method is not successful simply because it creates activity.

Useful struggle that must remain with the learner

Evidence that will distinguish learning from activity or polished performance

Signal that will tell me to pause, redesign, or stop

What learners said, created, attempted, or understood

What I will keep, adapt, release, or investigate

Chapter 13: The Foreknowledge Check • Evidence

Understand before acting. Never reduce a learner to a profile.

What I have actually observed

What I have inferred or assumed

What the learner has had an appropriate opportunity to share

Source of the information and the limits of that source

Relevant perspective that may be missing

Chapter 13: The Foreknowledge Check • Ethics

Information is useful only when it opens support rather than closes possibility.

Evidence that could challenge my first interpretation

How this interpretation opens support rather than closes possibility

Educational or safeguarding purpose this information serves

Policy, permission, or professional authority that allows its use

Possible harm if the information or interpretation is wrong

Chapter 13: The Foreknowledge Check • Action

Choose a move that can be corrected when better information arrives.

Smallest humane and reversible action

When I will revisit the decision

New evidence that appeared

Who helped widen the picture

How the interpretation changed

Privacy reminder

Keep identifying and confidential information out of unapproved tools and follow the policies governing your setting.

Field Tool 3: Reading the Room • Signals

Check only what you actually notice. A signal is not a diagnosis.

- ☐ Noise is rising without purpose.
- ☐ Silence feels heavy instead of focused.
- ☐ Movement no longer serves the task.
- ☐ Materials are being used without care.
- ☐ Learners are waiting without knowing what to do next.
- ☐ Learners are rushing without engaging with the challenge.
- ☐ Laughter repeatedly interrupts moments of uncertainty.
- ☐ A learner's words and visible cues appear not to match.
- ☐ Learners are busy but cannot explain what they are learning.

What I actually observed

Describe the signal without assigning motive.

What changed immediately before it

Field Tool 3: Reading the Room • Test

The better we name the possible problem, the wiser our response can become.

- ☐ This may involve clarity.
- ☐ This may involve energy.
- ☐ This may involve relationship.
- ☐ This may involve confidence.
- ☐ This may involve structure.
- ☐ This may involve timing.
- ☐ This may involve belonging.
- ☐ This may involve purpose.

Evidence supporting this reading

Alternative explanation

What else might create the same visible signal?

Smallest response worth testing

Signal that will make me reconsider

Field Tool 4: The Student Strength Finder

When a learner is struggling, look again.

Where does this learner show energy?

When do they become more focused?

What do they discuss with confidence?

What do they protect, avoid, or resist?

Who do they work well beside?

What task helps them feel capable?

CHOOSE ONE MOVE

- ☐ Offer one meaningful responsibility.
- ☐ Make the first step smaller.
- ☐ Offer one choice with clear boundaries.
- ☐ Create one chance to teach, model, organize, lead, repair, explain, or create.

Field Tool 5: The Teacher Self-Check

Use before correcting a person or entering a difficult conversation.

- ☐ I am correcting behaviour, not trying to win the moment.
- ☐ I am protecting learning, not my ego.
- ☐ I have separated what happened from how it made me feel.
- ☐ My response keeps a respectful way back visible.
- ☐ My response preserves dignity.
- ☐ I can name the smallest firm move that protects safety while keeping the relationship possible.

Emotion I need to recognize before acting

Evidence that challenges my first story

Smallest firm move

How the person can return with dignity

Hold both.

Discipline without dignity creates resistance. Relationship without direction creates drift.

Field Tool 6: The Responsible AI Checklist

Use whenever an intelligent system becomes part of teaching, learning, leadership, or design.

- ☐ This system is approved for this use, and I have checked how it handles information.
- ☐ Names, identifying details, confidential records, diagnoses, safeguarding information, private communications, and protected work have been kept out unless the system is specifically approved for that purpose.
- ☐ I am treating the output as a possibility to examine, not a fact or instruction to obey.
- ☐ I have checked the result for accuracy, appropriateness, context, and alignment.
- ☐ Dignity, privacy, creativity, judgment, and ownership remain visible.
- ☐ AI is widening possibilities without replacing accountable human responsibility.
- ☐ I could explain this use openly to the people affected by it.

What AI is being asked to do

What must remain humanly accountable

What I verified, corrected, rejected, or changed

High-stakes boundary

Do not ask AI to make safeguarding, emergency, disciplinary, diagnostic, or other high-stakes decisions. Follow approved procedures and involve the qualified people responsible.

Field Tool 7: Teaching AI Through Reflection

The goal is not to make human judgment smaller. It is to make the exchange more thoughtful and, where a system can adapt or learn from feedback, offer clearer human context, correction, and values.

Human value that must remain visible

What AI helped me see

What I corrected, rejected, or changed

Context the system may not have been able to see

Responsibility that remains mine

Pattern I would want repeated, if the system is designed to learn from this exchange

Field Tool 8: Pattern Practice • Recognize and Use

Study patterns to prepare more wisely, not to trap people inside predictions.

Pattern I am noticing

What usually happens before it appears

Evidence that may challenge the pattern

What this pattern helps me prepare for

Response that could protect learning before the pattern grows stronger

Field Tool 8: Pattern Practice • Create and Transcend

Mastery means understanding a pattern deeply enough to follow it, adapt it, release it, or transcend it.

Better pattern this moment may require

Routine, question, structure, or experience that could make it repeatable

Person or system that may hold part of the picture

What another perspective may help me notice

Part of the pattern I should follow, adapt, release, or transcend

Wiser pattern I am ready to create

Field Tool 9: Weekly Field Journal • Notice

Choose the prompts that matter most. You do not need to answer every field.

One moment I am proud of

One learner I need to understand better

One routine that needs attention

One relationship I should repair or strengthen

One strategy that worked

One strategy that needs to change

Field Tool 9: Weekly Field Journal • Learn

End with one small move rather than a promise to change everything.

One thing I learned from a learner

One thing I learned from feedback

One way AI or another perspective helped me think wider

One place where I need to trust my judgment more

One piece of evidence that changed my mind

One small move for next week

Field Tool 10: The Monday Move

If you do not know where to begin, begin small. Complete one before adding another.

- ☐ Ask one better question.
- ☐ Clarify one expectation.
- ☐ Repair one relationship.
- ☐ Rethink one routine.
- ☐ Notice one learner differently.
- ☐ Prepare one alternative path.
- ☐ Listen to one piece of feedback without defending myself.
- ☐ Use AI once to widen my thinking, then use my judgment to decide what belongs.

The one move I chose

Why this move matters now

Evidence I will watch for

What I learned before choosing another move

Field Tool 11: Terrain Inquiry · Read

Choose one class, learning space, team, or recurring moment.

Inquiry question

What am I trying to understand rather than prove?

Condition that appears to be shaping learning

What makes me think so

Record evidence and its limits.

Where an assumption may be filling a gap

Condition I cannot control

Condition I can influence

Field Tool 11: Terrain Inquiry · Respond and Observe

Change one condition so the evidence remains readable.

Single adjustment I will make

Why this adjustment is humane and reversible

What changed

What remained

Who responded differently

What I may still be missing

Field Tool 11: Terrain Inquiry · Listen and Revise

A disciplined inquiry allows other perspectives and later evidence to correct the first reading.

What learners noticed

What colleagues, assistants, families, or support staff noticed

Evidence that contradicted my expectation

What I will keep, adapt, or release

Next wiser move

Date I will review again

Honest claim

This inquiry can improve reflection and local practice. It does not, by itself, establish that the framework causes a particular outcome.

The Reality Check

Use when your interpretation may affect another person's opportunity, dignity, support, or future.

My current interpretation

Evidence supporting it

Evidence that does not fit

Perspective I have not yet heard

Question I can ask without leading the answer

What I am prepared to change

Partner Perspective

Invite another person to widen the picture, not merely confirm your position.

Context shared without unnecessary identifying details

What I think is happening

What my partner noticed differently

Question their perspective raised

Evidence we still need

Shared next move

Practice Evidence Log

Use one page for one tool, one adjustment, and one context. Reprint this page whenever needed.

Date and context

Tool used

Evidence before the move

One move or adjustment

Evidence afterward

Who else noticed, and what they saw

Evidence that complicates the result

Next revision

Thirty-Day Review

Look for growth in your practice without turning every change into proof.

Tool I actually used most

Tool I avoided, and why

Moment when evidence changed my mind

Pattern I now notice earlier

Relationship, routine, or learning condition that changed

What another person would say changed

What remains unresolved

One practice I will carry forward

Field-Test Feedback

These questions may improve a future edition or, if recurring questions reveal a deeper need, inspire a future book. Share no learner names or confidential information. Personal feedback is not universal evidence.

Tool or page tested

What felt immediately useful

What felt unclear, repetitive, or difficult to use

Prompt that changed how I saw the situation

Important perspective or context the tool missed

Would I use it again? Why or why not?

One change that would make the tool stronger

Final Reflection

The field is always changing. So must we.

What I now see more clearly

Where I still need humility

What I am ready to protect more deliberately

What I am ready to release

The next person or possibility I will look at differently

My next wiser move

Return to the field.

Prepare without becoming rigid. Care without losing judgment. Use tools without surrendering wisdom. Lead without forgetting the human being in front of you.